

A younger architect realizes lofty ambitions

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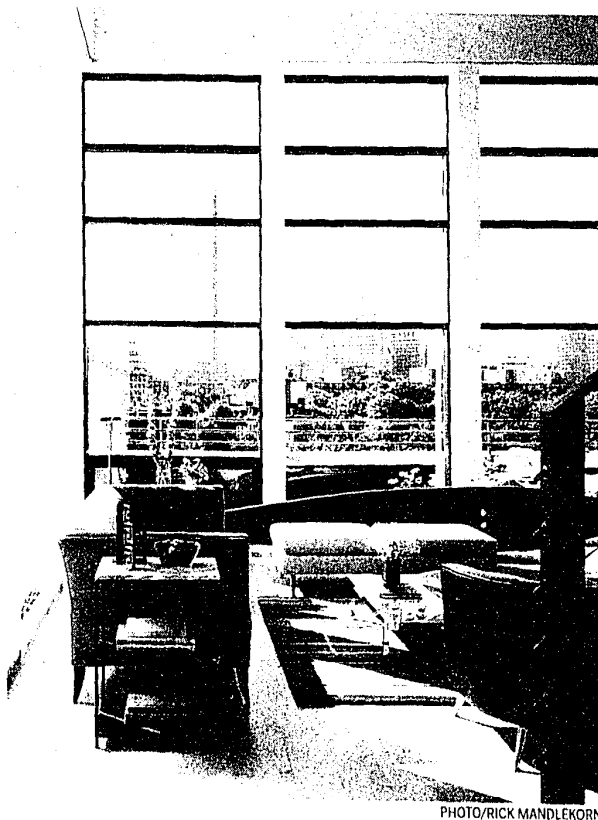
Architects give each other a lot of awards. More, surely, than those in other professions. Maybe that's because (a) architects are visual people who love to hang graphically elegant plaques on the office wall or (b) architecture, after all, is an art, and like any art — like movies or country music, for instance — it inspires people to give out grades, to make a "best" list.

Every year, the Boston Society of Architects announces its awards for outstanding architecture. In just the three central categories, which are honor awards for architecture plus special awards for interiors and for housing, there were no fewer than 37 prizewinners. Those who feel curious and indefatigable can get the CD that shows them all by e-mailing bsa@architects.org.

What sometimes stands out in the blizzard of prizes is the public arrival of a younger talent. David Hacin (pronounced hah-SEEN), who's had his own office for just eight years, took four of those 37 awards. Three of them are for a shop in San Francisco and a loft building and condo renovation in Boston. The one that intrigues me, though, is the prize for Hacin's own residence.

Hacin's loft has got to be one of the dozen best pads in all of greater Boston. It's in the part of the South End that people are now calling SoWa ("South of Washington"), by analogy with SoHo in New York. This neighborhood is suddenly popping with energy and vitality, especially from its many art galleries.

You can spot Hacin's loft from far away. It's tucked under a hood that pokes out boldly, rather like the stiff visor of an army general's hat, at the top of the Laconia Lofts building at 1200 Washington. The street bends a little here, leaving the visor as a kind of urban punc-



PHOTO/RICK MANDEKORN

David Hacin won four Boston Society of Architects awards, one for his own residence, a South End loft with a stellar view.

tuation mark, easily seen from both directions.

Hacin designed the entire Laconia building, for a developer who intended himself to move into the space beneath the visor. But he changed his mind and offered the raw, unfinished loft to Hacin. Hacin shaped it into a residence for himself and his partner, Tim Grafft, who is director of international marketing at the Massachusetts Office of Travel and Tourism.

What's so great about this fifth-story pad? First of all, there's the fantastic view to the north, of busy parks and playgrounds across the street, then beyond them the red brick and green trees of the South

End, and beyond that the Hancock Tower and Back Bay skyline. Hacin's loft aligns precisely with the axis of the Hancock, so you can see only the slim, blade-like edge of the tower. Hacin calls it a feng shui relationship.

A good place from which to enjoy this superb view is the outdoor balcony, which wraps two sides of the loft. But the view is equally accessible from the interior, which is lined with double-height windows. Besides a living-dining area and kitchen, the lower floor has a guest room with a wall made of panels that pivot to reveal the view, so you can lie in bed and watch the stars. This guest room

forms the lower half of a two-story cubelike shape that has been built beneath the loft's high ceiling.

The upper half of the cube contains Hacin's study, which functions like the pilot house of a ship: From it, you can visually monitor activity in almost every direction. Here, too, are the master bedroom and bath, treated as one single room without partitions. Again, pivoting white panels can be opened to reveal the view.

And the space directly beneath the general's visor? It's up another floor, reached by a short stair. It's a study for Grafft and his collection of thousands of vinyl LPs. During design and construction, Grafft was unaware that this space was going to be part of the loft. Hacin kept it hidden behind a fake partition, then opened it as a present on Grafft's birthday.

The Hacin-Grafft loft is cool and airy, as lofts are supposed to be, never cluttered and never over-decorated. Nor are there any of the obtrusively clever details or improbable materials you sometimes see in lofts that seek to be trendy. Floors are simple black slate or maple. Walls are mostly painted white. Furniture is modern, but not so modern you feel you're in a minimalist showroom. There's a pleasant sense that the different pieces don't quite match, that they've been collected separately over time, as indeed they have.

Hacin's other three winners this year are a Fresh store in California, one of a dozen he's done for this chain of soap and cosmetics retailers (there are four in the Boston area); another loft building in SoWa, called the Lofts at East Berkeley Street; and a condo tucked in an older building in Brookline. His office of 10 people is off and running, and it's pleasant to see him receive this recognition.

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